

Most Anticipated Games of 2009

Kumar Jhuremalani

2008 saw some great titles being released, but that's old news now. It's the New Year — let's move on. Games give us something to look forward to, when you get home from school, college, or even work. Enough talk. Let's jump into a list of the games that we are looking forward to this year. These games are in no particular order, because we definitely want to play them all!

Lord of the Rings Conquest (PC, PS3, Xbox 260, Nintendo DS)

The *Lord of the Rings: Conquest* is an upcoming video game developed by Pandemic Studios and published by Electronic Arts. It is based on *The Lord of the Rings* trilogy, and borrows many gameplay mechanics from Pandemic's *Star Wars: Battlefront* games. This game allows you to play both the forces of good and evil, but unlike *The Lord of the Rings: The Battle for Middle-earth*, the latter option is based around Sauron stopping the One Ring from being destroyed and fighting back. All sounds good on



paper, especially as it offers a choice of a side to pick in the epic war for the Rings, so let's wait and hope for the best. Go to www.pandemicstudios.com/conquest/ to find out more about this game.

Halo Wars (Xbox 360)

Halo is an all time favourite FPS game that has you playing as the spartan warrior Master Chief, of the UNSC. You have to battle the Covenant forces and achieve victory. *Halo Wars* has not been created by Bungie, but is instead more of an off-shoot of the *Halo* franchise, and is created by Ensemble Studios. The game offers a different perspective to the world and wars of *Halo*. As an RTS game, you get to control large armies and shrewdly direct them in realistic warfare. *Halo Wars* is set during the UNSC's first deadly encounters with the Covenant, allowing players to lead the crew of the UNSC's "Spirit of Fire" — from initial skirmishes to an all



out war against the Covenant. So all you RTS lovers who really didn't understand the hype behind *Halo*, should now set yourselves up to get hooked. *Halo Wars*' web site is www.halowars.com.

Tom Clancy's Splinter Cell: Conviction (Xbox 360, PC)

Conviction, is the fifth among the popular *Splinter Cell* series. This game is being developed by Ubisoft Montreal. The story takes place two years after the events of *Tom Clancy's Splinter Cell: Double Agent*. Sam Fisher is forced out of hiding because of an unspecified danger to his friend and co-worker, Anna Grimsdóttir. Upon his return to Third Echelon, he discovers that the organisation has fallen into disarray due to overbearing bureaucracy and internal power struggles. Incensed by the inability of Third Echelon to do what's right, Sam strikes out on his own. In *Conviction*, Sam's involvement with the terrorists in *Double Agent* has made him a wanted man, forcing him to go incognito. For those of you who haven't played any of the previous *Splinter Cell* games, Sam is a part of a special black ops team under the NSA, code named Third Echelon and Anna Grimsdóttir is the technical operations manager in the same department. The game offers a good mix of stealth gameplay (think *Metal Gear Solid* series, and action). This particular outing of Sam promises to be as exciting as the previous installments with its interesting information gathering gameplay, stealth, and covert missions. For more information about this game go to <http://splintercell.us.ubi.com/conviction/>.



Street Fighter IV (Xbox 360, PS3, PC)

Street Fighter lovers rejoice! The game is back with added features, characters and game styles. Gear up for new moves and combos including four new characters — Abel, Crimson Viper, Rufus and El Fuerte. Of course there are boss and hidden characters that these arcade games always hold —



Gouken, Seth and Akuma. Even though the characters are being rendered in 3D, the gameplay is not going to change. *Street Fighter IV* is retaining the arcade style of six button combat. There are

two more attacks that have been added to this game — Focus Attack and Ultra Combo. The game is already released on arcades, but will have more to offer for the home version, which will be releasing shortly. *Street Fighter*'s web site is www.streetfighter.com

BioShock 2: Sea of Dreams (Xbox 360, PS3, PC)

What can we say about *BioShock*? Those of you who have played the game, absolutely love it. If you haven't played it, well, you are missing out on an award-winning title. Now it's time to play the sequel of the game coming out in 2009 titled, *BioShock 2: Sea of Dreams*. Here's the problem though — not much has been revealed about the sequel. So much so, that there is speculation that the game may be a prequel instead of a sequel. A teaser for the *Sea of Dreams* is available on popular video sites

